up watching. A packed crowd chanting 'Sachin, Sachin' in frenzied unison became almost like a national cricket anthem for over two decades, culminating in a magical night at the Wankhede. A memorable quote of the 2011 triumph was from Sachin's heir apparent, Virat Kohli, who summed up the feelings of the team: "He (Sachin) has carried the burden of the nation for 21 years, it was time we carried him."

Sachin, of course, has since retired into iconic Bharat Ratna status. Dhoni, that other great talisman of the 2011 triumph, still plays as a Chennai Superking folk hero, having permanently bridged Indian cricket's north-south divide. In 2011, it was Dhoni's calm and control that was crucial to victory in the final against Sri Lanka. Now the burden to achieve a hat-trick of World Cup successes falls on the worthy inheritor who lifted Sachin on his shoulders for the lap of honour in 2011. 'King' Kohli is already a sporting legend, having redefined Indian cricket by taking physical fitness and a never-say-die attitude to another level. He has established himself as arguably the greatest one-day cricketer of all time—statistically even ahead of West Indian master batsman Viv Richards—Kohli has a chance to rewrite the record books again: become the first Indian cricketer to win two World Cups in the 50-over format.

Kohli's presence in the side is a reminder that international sport is a baton relay where one generation mentors the next: new stars are emerging, but the old order isn't calling it a day just yet. Captain Rohit Sharma made his debut in 2007, but 16 years later is, when on song, still the most devastating shotmaker in the team. Kohli and Sharma in partnership are a classy *jugalbandi* (duet) for purists, but the sport itself now plays to a very different beat.

Cricket is no longer a languid sport played with a sense of timelessness as part of a gently unfolding drama. Five-day Test cricket is already facing an existential crisis, one reason why England's recent free-spirited, positive approach (nicknamed 'Bazball' after their Kiwi coach Brendon McCullum) has won so many hearts. Even the relevance of the 50-over game is under the microscope: who really wants to see batsmen nudging the ball around for singles and twos in the middle overs any longer? White-ball cricket is now almost an unrecognisable sport, played with supersonic speed, where raw power, athleticism and fearless inventiveness are qualities to be treasured above all else. Amidst the proliferation of T20 leagues across the world, we now even have T10 tournaments and hundred balls per side contests attracting large crowds in an atmosphere akin to a high-decibel rock concert. Not to forget the unimaginable



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